

Michael Milken, Meet
Sewell Avery
James Grant

Trammell Crow, the king of the surviving Dallas real estate developers and a charter Forbes Four Hundred member, is credited with a number of pithy business sayings. Builders are leveraged and optimistic fellows, and some of Crow's remarks are inspirational, e.g., "The way to wealth is debt." However, recent goings-on in the credit markets may force a revision in that epigram. The updated version may read, less pithily, "The way to wealth in a bull market is debt. The way to oblivion in a bear market is also debt, and nobody rings a bell."

Debt is the original fair-weather friend. It is with you on the upside, and against you on the downside. So long has the financial sun been shining that it seems—especially to the bulls on Wall Street—as if the skies will never darken. But if you can acknowledge the possibility of even one inclement business season, you will want to reflect on the leveraged American condition, and on many of the private American fortunes that constitute the Forbes Four Hundred. You will want to consider that debt may become just as unpopular one day as it now is popular. You may want to anticipate how a forward-thinking investor might profit from such a turn in events.

When the legendary showman P. T. Barnum stretched to buy his American Museum more than a century ago, a friend